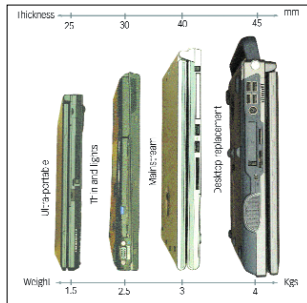


BUYING A LAPTOP

Size Matters

 Size and weight are important considerations when buying a laptop. If you travel a lot,



opt for a laptop that is light in weight. Weights of laptops range from one to four kg. While checking the weight, include everything you will carry along with the notebook, such as the power adaptor or any external drives.

See Your Screen

 The size of the display screen directly affects the size, and in most cases, the weight, of the notebook. The larger the screen, the bulkier the notebook. A bulky notebook will be a problem to use in cramped locations such as in an airplane.

Power Struggle

 Though performance is not the most important criterion while purchasing a notebook, make sure you get enough horsepower for the applications you use or plan to use. While 256 MB of RAM should suffice for most, power users should opt for at least 512 MB.

All Work And No Play?

 If you want to play 3D games, or plan to use your laptop for some graphics-intensive applications, opt for a model that features good-quality graphics. Options available include Mobility Radeon 7500, 9700 and GeForce FX Go5200.

These will give you better graphics as compared to commonly-used platforms.

Go Wirefree

 Most notebooks today offer Wi-Fi capabilities. Check the Wi-Fi standard supported by the model you are considering for purchase. An 802.11 b/g device will give you higher data throughput as compared to 802.11b.

Upgrade

 Check if the notebook is upgradeable at a later stage. Some options to look for when upgrading your laptop are the RAM, the CPU, and the hard drive. Are the upgrades something you can do yourself, or do they require visits to a service centre?

Build Quality Is Important

 Since laptops are meant to be carried around, good build quality is essential. Opt for a notebook that has a rugged build quality that can withstand jerks and shocks. The optical drive tray, the screen hinges and latch, the panel on top of the keyboard, and the overall casing are good indicators of build quality.

Warranty Issues

 Warranty is also an important consideration. Make sure you get a global warranty if you travel abroad frequently. Even if you don't, make sure the service centre is easily accessible in terms of location and distance so you can get any problems rectified quickly.

Optical Drives

 Most notebooks these days come with a DVD/CD-RW combo drive by default. Make sure the notebook you plan to buy has a combo drive if not a DVD-Writer. A combo drive will enable you to read DVDs as well as write CDs.

Optical Drive Location

 Check for the location of the optical drive. An optical drive placed in the front may be a hindrance while working in cramped spaces, or when the notebook is placed on your lap.

Wider Is Better

 Notebooks that come with wide screens offer a better movie-viewing experience. They are also useful while working with



large spreadsheets. Also, look for decent quality integrated speakers if you want to enjoy movies and music on the move.

Hot Laps

 Make sure the notebook you plan to buy does not get too hot after a while. A hot laptop on your lap may pose a serious health risk!

Storage

 Most notebooks come with 40 GB hard drives. If this does not seem enough, see if you can get an upgrade to a larger capacity hard drive. The drive's



rotational speed also impacts performance. While 4200 rpm drives are the most common, look for higher rpm hard drives for better performance.

Go Legal

 When purchasing a laptop, make sure it comes with legal software. Some vendors may not provide you with legal copies of the software. Verify that the software that comes with your laptop is on an original CD, and has a software license or registration number.

Laptop Drivers

 Check and make sure you get all the required drivers on a disk along with the laptop. A recovery disk is also preferable, and will come in handy in case of a system crash.

Connectivity Options

 The available ports on a notebook will define the types and number of peripheral devices you can connect. Most notebooks come with 56K modems and at least 10/100 Ethernet integrated, so the notebook will have RJ11 and RJ45 ports for connecting a telephone cord and a network cord respectively.

Typically, you should look for at least two USB ports, a parallel port to connect a printer, a VGA port for connecting a projector or an external monitor, and Audio Out and Mic In ports to connect speakers and a microphone respectively.

PC card slots are also essential, and you should check the types of PC cards that are supported. An infrared port, if available, will let you connect compatible devices such as cell phones to your notebook, while a FireWire port lets you connect digital such devices as video cameras. Look for these ports if you feel you will require them even at a later stage. Additional ports such as S-video out are also welcome!

One-handed Operation

 Some notebook models, especially those with larger screens, come with two latches that will require you to use both your hands to open the device. This may be inconvenient in some situations, for instance, when you are speaking on the phone. Look for a laptop that has a single latch.

Touch The Pad

 Most notebooks these days feature touchpads. Make sure the laptop you plan to buy has one that is large and offers smooth and jerk-free control of the pointer. Some notebooks